

Lecture #8

The Kabbalah: Jewish mysticism

kabbalah means tradition and has several basic elements

1. it believes there are two sources of truth:

first is mystical experience- this is the source of revelation.

In the Jewish understanding it is not just an

as well

intuitive experience as in India, but is intellectual

they are very careful not to say 'I am

it is theistic.

divine".

the second source is the Hebrew Bible as given to Moses on Sinai.

laws:

they believe as the pharisees did, that there are two written and oral.

one of the key elements for the Jews is you must keep the laws--follow the Torah (written law) and the talmud (the oral law.)

mystics emphasize the experience first and reinterpret the Bible to explain their experience.

these two (experience and Sinai) cannot contradict each other.

2. the internal unity of God is one of Jewish mysticism's main concerns.

Greek philosophy taught God had to be simple--can't give God attributes. The Bible does talk about attributes of God such as love, goodness, power, etc.

mystics wanted to emphasize that God is a living organism His attributes (sefirot)

are not just names of God or descriptions--they are a world or realm of divinity that underlie the sense data and are part of life of God Himself.

The World of the Sefirot solved the problem of the attributes of God--a progression of the differentiation that is in God. This doesn't happen in time or space--they are stages of divinity emanating out of God.

the mystical experience was seen as experiencing these world of the sefirot in stages but you could never reach the essence of God.

God known as En Sof meaning infinity, spoken of

of as root of

roots" and in impersonal terms.

3. Torah is basic text of mystic. sees as a **living** organism—living incarnation that has life itself. it sends out rays of illumination.

Hebrew is a holy tongue and mystics don't talk about their experience and there are no women mystics in Judaism.

4. Secrecy of Mystical knowledge esoteric and passed one to one. young are **not** to read Ezekial 1 and 2 (the chariot throne vision) as it is dangerous. also, Gen 1 the work of creation as many secrets found there.

5. reinterpretation of traditional concepts.

1. history was reinterpreted as event in the soul, as the coming out of Egypt was seen as the individuals growth.

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2. the ten commandments were seen with a new meaning. they make another realm of existence transparent that can be grasped intuitively. by keeping the commandments it has an effect on this world and the heavenly domains (world of the sefirot) commandments are seen in a cosmic setting.

So the

Merkabah mysticism

the Merkabah was the chariot throne seen by Ezekial in chap 1 and 2 and also seen by Isaiah in chap. 6.

it developed in the first century and lasted till about the 10th cent and was called "those who go down to the chariot.

7 heavens were believed in and in each heaven is a palace (hekalot) and each palace has a gate keeper.

--in the 7th heaven are seven palaces and seven gatekeepers.

--when you get to the 7th palace of the 7th heaven you are in the presence of the chariot throne, the vision Ezekial had.

--mystical experience is working your way thru the heavens to this vision with the goal of seeing the Merkabah.

to get there one must 1. fulfill the commandments and 2. must have a teacher to teach you the secrets of getting there, including the secret words needed to get by the gatekeepers.

key concept is of God as king.

radical difference between

divine and human. when get there you don't see God, you see the throne.

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--get a higher knowledge—seeing things as they are

--speak of God's body-Shir Komar-related to the song of songs (chap. 5) had idea of measuring God's body and had demensions that were very large. popular in medieval times. Jaloud tells of 4 rabbis who ascended to the 7th heaven and saw the vision. one looked at chariot throne and died, another looked and went crazy another looked and began to tear up plants, Rabbi Akiba looked and came out in peace.

Akiba warns people of danger of ascending there. still elements of this present today.

there are

The Zohar "The Book of Splendor"

written in 1275 or 76 was the greatest production of Jewish mystical religion. It is a mystical commentary on the Pentateuch covering the creation, early stories, the patriarchs, exodus, law, priesthood and the wilderness experience, etc.

written in Aramaic is was purported to be **written** by a first century rabbi but this could not be.

it is not systematic and rarely cites the tradition but is closely tied to the scriptures.

The Iree of the Sefirat is the main object of meditation. This is the way God manifests himself. this doctrine believes mystics can perceive and describe the living God.

almost every word in scripture can be tied to a sepirot. all refer to the inner life of God

the name of Torah is one great and Holy name of God

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the Sepirot are considered something within the non-differentiated divine life which breaks thru in creation.

there is a world also that is intelligible only to God and our finite world of phenomena.

when these two worlds are attached called the world of the Befirot. . its on this 2nd world we can come to know God.

1. world of En sof
2. world of Sefirot
3. world of phenomena

The ten sefirot are thought of in order from most far removed from humans to the closest but they are all interconnected.

these 10 in order are: 1) kether elyon-supreme crown; 2) hokmah-wisdom of God; 3) binah-intelligence; 4) hesod-steadfast love; 5) geburah-power as in severity; 6) rahamin-beauty or compassion; 7) hod-majesty; 8) yesod-foundation of all active forces in God; 9) Netsah-eternity, lasting endurance of God; and 10) malkut-kingdom of God, his presence in the community.

Malkut is most important the lowest as is heavenly mode of community of Israel. Idea that what happens to Israel as a Community affects heaven.

the world is thought of in terms of an organism God and Man. all would be inter-connected with everything else like the sap of En Sof flowing thru everything in Malkut the Shekinah or uncreated light is present

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God speaks three pronouns:

He when God has just decided to manifest himself but hasn't done it yet. most deeply hidden

You has completely unfolded himself down to # 5.

I> completely to # 10-supreme manifestation.

the divine I is most profound-God has completely manifested Himself. the human can penetrate to You and He. Human learns about himself as well as God can penetrate God's very speech. Creation in our world is an external aspect of something which already happened in God. So creation of world is really life of God (externally) everything is external image of God> soul is in the image and likeness of God. Not quite pantheism but close.

Genesis is really actual creation of another world in life of God on which the creation of this world is based. that other world is the world of the Sefirot upon which our world is modeled.

the second creation allows separation and differentiation since God also was without form before creation.

why does the Bible start with the second letter of the Hebrew alphabet?

because it is creation of 2 worlds

Mystics interested in uniting with God, not necessarily the world.

the Zohar tells us what we will see in experiencing God but doesn't tell us of the feeling

6

Divine Life the living God is known in the 10 sefirot. Not in En Sof. En Sof is the God that can't be known--not the living God.

spheres #4-12 make up the seven days of creation.

with 19,

malkut, which is the sabbath, blessing all the other days. these 7 sefirot are a model for our world.

they felt it was only the mystic who was getting through to the soul of the Torah. mystical experience.

they judged all Jews who don't have

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Abulafia Mysticism (1240-after 1272)

this was an opposing school to the mysticism of the Zohar.
emphasis is on ecstatic experience

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aim was to "unseal the soul or "to untie the binds". -means
mystical experience is attempt to regain an original unity with
God.

the soul is bound, sealed, tied down so must find ways to
help the soul perceive the spiritual

if we can contemplate on abstract spiritual matters then the
soul will not be bound but freed.

He determined that meditating on the Hebrew alphabet and
studying them one could free the soul since the alphabet has no
relation to the world.

things like angels, death, etc. were not appropriate since
they are not abstract

one must meditate on things that are both abstract and not an

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object--the Hebrew alphabet is that thing since the letters
themselves are letters of God's name

calls it "mystical logic"

Dve kut meaning "adhesion" is the experience one will have of
God.

this is agreement of the will of man with the will of God

1. when your will agrees with God's will then one is
perpetually with God.

"I do anything I want because I am changed and do whatever God
wants.

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2. the mystic and God can't be separated. the mystic is
elevated with rank while God has it naturally. the mystic is
elevated to the rank of God.

in the mystic state, the human
being and Torah are one. God is wholly in it.

3. dve kut is the state that the prophets were in when in the
Hebrew Bible they declared the word of God.

it is being "one with the world of light."

Fath to dve kut

1. scholarship--must know the law, keep torah and know the
science of the combination of letters since they contain God's

pane.

God's word--he spoke and it was so. since the Hebrew alphabet is neither an object and are abstract and things exist only in the degree they are in the name of God, then contemplation of the letters is breaking the key to creation.

there is harmonious movement of pure thought--the world is the manifestation of God's word.

every letter and word are significant. and every letter also one gets into numerology also.

has a number

Lurianic mysticism

Isaac Luria (1534-1572) lived at Safed in Israel, the center of much mystical speculation as well as scholarship after the Jews were forced from Spain in 1492.

at this time messianic expectation ran high and the Zohar was running out of steam at this time so the time was right for a PEN approach.

This was neo platonism in its views. Creation came out of nothing and emanated from God. These two things had to be reconciled.

The Lurianic school of mystics, engaged in an inner process of soul searching, and developed a doctrine of redemption which both offered an explanation of the external reality of intensified suffering in exile and presented a new path for internal spiritual salvation.

The doctrine of *tsin tsum* or contraction was the basis for their mysticism. This was the notion that God, in order to create the world, had to impose limits upon himself. He had to retreat into himself in order to make space for the creation of the universe, so that in the very first act of creation a negative element was present.

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He had to go into exile himself so the creation could take place.

the second thing involved was that when God created the world he sent out his divine light, which was contained within form-giving vessels or spheres. sun and moon.

this is his primal light, not

this means that there is something divine in every being and every being has its own reality.

Evil came into the world because when God contracted his power and judgement became clearly defined.

before God creates, the Sefirot are all in view. but with creation Geburah or power (severity) brings evil.

Doctrine of the Breaking of the vessels

When God's light shot out, the first being was world.

created--primordial Adam--a giant man who stands behind the

From his eyes ears and nose, the sefirot shine forth.

Thus the differentiation of the sefirot begin and each must be contained in a vessel.

the three highest sefirot go into their own vessel but next **six** broke when light entered them.

WHY

?

because the light of the last six sefirot was already mixed with forces of **evil**.

when vessels broke some of the light flowed back to God, Some in world, and some was imprisoned in matter.

our world then is these sparks of light and that which is enclosed in matter.

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the world is good which is the light but matter (neo-platonically) is evil.

each person has a spark of divinity in them so

goal is to free the light from matter, return it to God and restore to the whole, in other words, reverse the process.

Tikkun is the process by which one liberates the sparks.

Human must do certain things :

first. prayer leads the soul back thru the creation.

is the symbol of the process of creation.

on mystical experience.

second. keeping the commandments

third. mystical study of the torah.

prayer

true prayer is modled

all must be done iwth honesty and openness--when tikkun is complete then the messiah will come asd a representation of the mystical redemption that has taken place.

all acts must be done with appropriate intention.

reincarnation Luria believed in this--all souls were sparks of divne light and eventually will rejoin Adam's soul.

If ones soul is reborn as a human soul it may be because of punishment or another life.

one can also be reincarnated as a non-human, either higer or

lower.

it takes a long time to return to ones maker but can shorten the time by pennence, prayer and study.

he believed the end of the world was coming in the 16th cent. and looked for the messi ah

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this was seen by many Jews as being fulfilled in the mid-seventeenth century when Sabbetai Zevi, was seen as the messiah.

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Hasidism

had earlier roots but came to full blossom in the 18th century in Eastern Europe.

The hope of the messiah coming was running so high that many came claiming to be the messiah before the middle of the 18th century.

hasidism was the result of the various failures of the messiah to appear.

it centered on the community of Israel--what happens to Israel affects the Godhead.

emphasis

1. community was the place of the experience of the divine

2

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Ideal man--before this it was study that was ideal but in mysticism, it is the one who knows the higher truth.

the ideal man is the charismatic figure who is the center of a community of followers, who has been illuminated and in contact with the divine.

he does symbolic acts, all acts of the leader are symbolic.

Zaddik is the name given to this leader. he is the one who is righteous, the embodiment of virtues and righteousness.

talk about God in familiar terms,

zaddiks do strange things.

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like Chung Tzu spoke of the Tao as the "Great Clod. and even curse God."

belief was that the zaddik has to descend to help us. helps the whole person, not just the spiritual part

de kut comes to man to be in constant union with

God

conscience that your will is the same as God's will.

Kavanah means having the right intention--emotion is important in this

goal is the redemption of souls. they did not believe you could hurry the end of time and bring the messiah. rather, their goal was to convert whole communities and make mysticism available to all. tried to find more value in everyday life.

thus, there was less emphasis on mystical practices and more on everyday life.

Baal Shem Tov (1760-1810) from Poland was the founder. name meant "master of the good name."

he knew the name of God and somehow had correctly related to Him.

he was

an unlearned enthusiast and wonder-worker but he capture the hearts of thousands among the simple pious folk and among the educated.

joy was emphasized.

service was given in joy and the

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experience of God is a joyful experience--emotional experience and is fun!

this joy can be found in:

1. service of the community,
2. appreciation of nature
3. taking one virtue and trying to embody it perfectly
4. prayer and keeping the commandments and meditation

shekinah is found in the community of Israel since this is the place where God is present. thus one looks for this experience of God in the community. this is the embodiment of the 10th sefirot and is the closest thing to God on earth.

Zaddik is the model of what the mystic is--spiritual leader. He is approached by members to decide on problems. He is not necessarily a scholar but he gives the community its direction and also relies on the community to help him in his work.

they are such strong leaders that they seldom could get along with each other.

key was that he who as attained the highest degree of spiritual solitude and can be alone with God can then be the center of the community.

they believe there are 36 hidden saints to help the world.
without them God would destroy the world.
there is the necessity of a teacher. their doctrine is passed on

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in various tales about the teachers.
tales

One who understands the

sees deeper meanings in the torah and in life.
goal was to see life in the way God would want us to see life.
our wil become God's wil. must give up ones own desires and
change them to God's desires.
Hasidic mystical activities regenerated a religious life which
had become alien and ossified for many.
Hasidic leaders were also rabbis and the rabbinc tradition was
integrated with hasidic ideas and practices in the formation of
new vital religious communities.
The Hasidic movement occurred within the structure of rabbinic
FJudaism, demonstrating the continuing ability of the traditional
ideas and forms to develop and accommodate the multiples needs of
the religious spirit.